

# Ludic Musicking: Musical Games and the Art of Negotiation and Distributed Agency.

Nicholas Cornia

Orpheus Instituut  
nicholas.cornia@orpheusinstituut.be

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## Abstract

This essay uses the devices of dialogue, fiction and game design in order to illustrate the principles of ludic musicking, an attitude towards music-making that encourages playfulness, distribution of agency and negotiation. The ludic musician embraces this lack of personal agency in order to let a novel set of experiences emerge from the game system. The ludic musicking's ethos is all about leaving blanks on the map and playing to find out. Alongside this written essay, the reader can experience the article through an ad-hoc designed dungeon delving board game and its playthrough recording made by the author in collaboration with his colleagues at Orpheus Instituut.

The narrow corridors and dark rooms of a dungeon have long been a powerful archetypal figure for Western culture, which projected in these labyrinthic underground systems its deepest fantasies and ancestral fears. Such chthonic spaces have been part of collective imagination, from the Renaissance *grottesco* to Gothic horror and science fiction. According to tabletop role-playing scholars, a (mega)dungeon is a huge—yet confined—non-linear space with an underlying structure and agenda reacting and emerging from players' agency (Roast 2023). The archetype of the dungeon can therefore serve as a metaphor for well-designed games and ludic musicking (Small 1998). Analogously, our claim is to provide a plea for musicking that embraces playfulness, distributed agency and openness by absorbing and re-composing concepts from ludology and game design into artistic research discourse.

## 1 Dungeons in our Minds

We all have dungeons in our minds. Dungeons unexplored, unending. Each of us gets lost in the dungeon, every night alone<sup>1</sup>.

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1. This fabricated citation is inspired by the Ursula K. Le Guin quote “We all have forests in our minds. Forests unexplored, unending. Each of us gets lost in the forest, every night alone.” from

Ludic musicking advances the production of knowledge through processes emerging from dynamics of negotiation between players, game-mechanics and

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her introduction to her short story *Vaster than Empires and More Slow*, in (Le Guin [1975] 2015).

artefacts. The assemblage of distributed agencies arising from musical games is an interesting, yet underdeveloped field. Rather than relying on complicated AI agents in order to generate emergent playing spaces, our investigation focuses on the aesthetic and epistemological value of games as imaginary worlds, i.e. collaboratively created fictional entities (Wolf 2014), able to let the participant explore alternative modes of agency (Nguyen 2020).

Musical games are not a novelty, but this essay attempts to provide a definition based on the contemporary theoretical framework of game design and ludology. Ludic musicking is a playful attitude towards meaningful, open, unexpected, and negotiable actions in music making. It invites musicians to “add ambiguity to the world, and play with that ambiguity” (Sicart 2017, 28).

## 1.1 What Dragons Eat

“You know what dragons eat?”  
Birt nodded and said in a whisper, “Maidens.” (Le Guin [1964] 2014, 285)

*The Rule of Names* is a short fantasy story by Ursula K. Le Guin that foreshadowed the imaginary world of the *Earthsea* saga. In this realm of islands, dragons and magic, power is synonym with the knowledge of the ancestral name of things and beings. Likewise countless scholars of the Early Modern period searching for the *clavis universalis*—the primordial language of the Creator—the wizards of *Earthsea* gain control over their surroundings by retrieving the real name of things in order to transform them at their leisure<sup>2</sup>.

2. For more information about the Early Modern obsession with artificial languages and the universal tongue of the creator, see (Eco 1996).

Similarly, researchers need to shape the right terminology to encompass their ideas. The theoretical framework of *ludic musicking* resonates with the concepts of open work, assemblage, actor-network theory, distributed agency, participatory art, and collective composition. Eco’s open work encourages art to embrace ambiguity and incompleteness as its main feature, rather than a flaw (Eco [1962] 1989), while Attali’s concept of collective composition (Attali [1977] 2009, Ch. 5) and Rancière’s emancipation of the spectator (Rancière 2009) have questioned the Western rigid hierarchical structure between author and reader, performer and audience, in favor of a more heterarchical and fluid dynamics of power relations. Finally, the non-linear and ever-changing structure of assemblages (De Landa 2016), Latour’s actor-networks (Latour 1996), and distributed agential systems (Garud and Karnøe 2005) have broken with a millennia-long tradition of binary classification and taxonomies of Western culture dating from Greek philosophy. The aforementioned concepts are consolidated with recent theories of ludology and aesthetic of play for the rising art form of gaming in our 21st century society (Upton 2015; Nguyen 2020; Sicart 2017).

Like democracy, these non-hierarchical entities are fragile: ludic musicking aims to provide a methodology for musical practices that wish to emancipate themselves from the concepts of authority and linear narratives.

## 1.2 A Little Wrinkling

What is music but a little wrinkling of the air? (Le Guin [1977] 2015)

The vision on musical games or game pieces<sup>3</sup> as proposed by this essay is rooted in a twenty-first-century aesthetic of play that perceives games as “the art form about choices and consequences” (Lantz 2023, 103). Games can here be understood as, on the one hand, *choices* implying that the *horizon of action*—the space of possibilities at a given game-state—of a player is not trivial (Upton 2015, 45–49), and, on the other hand, *consequences* that these choices are meaningful—i.e. their actions have a reasonable impact on the playing space (Salen and Zimmerman 2004).

When interacting with a musical game—either at the compositional or performative level—every agent is subjugating their free will and artistic inspiration to constraints derived from random outcomes, other players’ actions or internal rules. Using Upton’s terminology, the player’s *horizon of action* is limited—and in well-designed games—has a reasonable overlap with their *horizon of intent*. At first glance, the fact that these two horizons do not coincide seems to be a flaw, but it is due to these discrepancies between player’s intentions and in-game constraints that unexpected and creative aesthetic experiences emerge. An elegant musical game lies at the liminal space between frustration and boredom.

Similarly to the villainous mastermind behind a dungeon, the designer of a (musical) game is facilitating experiences, rather than fixing paths. To paraphrase game scholar Miguel Sicart, the stance of

the designer is a curatorial one, setting a stage and fruitful constraints for player agency (Sicart 2017, 90). Moreover, the aim for a designer is not to control and predict all the possible trajectories, but to give room for unexpected and unforeseen paths and interactions with the rules—or game-mechanics.

While considering dedicated platforms for musical games—such as *Games for Music* (“Games for Music” 2018), or at seminal works like Zorn’s *Cobra* (1984), Xenakis’ *Stratégie* (1962) and Stockhausen’s *Klavierstück XI* (1956)—one crucial aspect is often neglected: the negotiating act between artistic freedom and the unexpected. The ludic musician embraces this lack of personal agency in order to let a novel set of experiences emerge from the game system. This novel artistic attitude is all about leaving blanks on the map and playing to find out.

As case studies we shall now consider two musical games that have been designed by the author of this essay: *Sorti Madrigalistiche* and *A Gothic Gamebook* (2025)<sup>4</sup>. *Sorti Madrigalistiche* is a corpus-based composition inspired by fortune-telling books and tarot cards, in order to generate a polyphonic piece upon a given poem. The curator assembles a corpus of 22 musical schemata—i.e. contrapuntal archetypal gestures—each associated to a Major Arcana card. The players select a poem, each verse for which they draw a Major Arcana card visually representing the musical scheme. An elegant mechanism of combinatorial wheels—each associated with the hexachord and mode

3. The term *game piece* has been introduced by twentieth-century composers such as John Zorn in order to define their open-ended musical compositions, involving decision-making and meaningful play from the performers. For more information, see (Weiss 2017).

4. Both games are available via GitHub Pages on the following URLs: [https://nicholascorniaorpheus.github.io/a\\_gothic\\_gamebook/](https://nicholascorniaorpheus.github.io/a_gothic_gamebook/) and [https://nicholascorniaorpheus.github.io/sorti\\_madrigalistiche/](https://nicholascorniaorpheus.github.io/sorti_madrigalistiche/).

of the schema—challenges the composers to cope with the unexpected transformations of the musical material. The result is a polyphonic piece driven by chance and negotiation.

A *Gothic Gamebook* is a musical game inspired by European supernatural and gothic culture of the nineteenth century presented during the second edition of the *Oddities and Rarities* music festival in November 2025<sup>5</sup>. The author of the essay has taken the role of facilitator, creating a musical experience shaped by Romantic German song repertoire and twentieth-century ergodic literature of gamebooks (Arnaudo 2023). During the course of the concert, the audience was asked to vote in order to direct the choices of two fictional lovers dealing with injustice and the uncanny. Each choice led to a scene with a short and evocative description, accompanied by a predefined song. The public was empowered with a degree of engagement not usually experienced during performances of similar repertoire, while the five singers and pianists discovered a playful and fresh approach towards the otherwise ossified repertoire of German Lied.

Rather than concrete musical objects, these musical games provide the reader with tools in order to generate their own musical *playworld*, by altering the musical corpus and adjusting the game-mechanics in order to facilitate a specific experience.

### 1.3 Did Games Create Computers?

Computers didn't create games, games created computers. (Zimmerman 2015)

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5. Official website of the event (in Dutch): <https://orpheusinstituut.be/nl/nieuws-en-events/oddities-rarities>

The kind of aesthetic entity we are proposing here is a process, a system, rather than a finite artefact. Ludic musicking escapes ossification through its inherent openness and deliberate blanks. A musical game is an example of an *open work* (Eco [1962] 1989), inviting all participants to step into a *magic circle* outside of the actual world (Salen and Zimmerman 2004, 95–97) where agency is distributed and negotiation is prioritised above authorship.

The term distributed agency has been used in the field of Computer Science to indicate a process shaped by a series of actors, with different ends and motivations. The outcome results from the complex interaction between the actor's agencies, escaping the classical definition of authorship. This concept finds fruitful applications in Artificial Intelligence, and it is rooted in the study of agential networks and non-human organization minds (Sandelands and Stablein 1987). Rather than investigating the agential space made possible by complicated computer technologies, our aim is to exploit the remarkable relational network between players, game-mechanics and (conflicting) ends.

In games, contrary to ordinary life, we take up ends for the sake of the means. This implies that we can create *disposable ends*—objectives that have value only within the boundaries of the in-game *magic circle*—in order to favor a particular form of agential experience, something we could not otherwise face (Nguyen 2020, Chap. 2). Instead of an ill-defined artwork—with all its paradoxes and ironies—a designer of a musical game models a space of possibilities, an imaginary world where unfamiliar agencies are experienced.

## 1.4 Where Did You Fall To?

Where did you fall to, and what did you discover? (Guin [1972] 2015, 9)

In the introduction to her science fiction novel *The Word for World is Forest* (1972) Ursula K. Le Guin shares with her readers a curious anecdote: after the publication of her story, the anthropologist Charles Tart pointed out a striking resemblance between Le Guin’s fictional civilization of the *Athshean* with the dream practices of the Senoi people of Malaysia. Artists constantly blur the artificial boundaries between the real and unreal: “the imaginary and the rational – the visionary and objective vision – hover closer together” (Haraway 1988, 585). Imaginary worlds—coherent fictional spaces shared by a community of people—have played a crucial role in our Western culture during the last centuries by providing a remedy from the disillusion of modernity through the *reenchantment* of the world (Saler 2012). These *sub-creations*<sup>6</sup> emulates the actual world with a combination of familiar and unfamiliar features, while keeping internal consistency and verisimilitude (Wolf 2014).

Similarly to shared imaginary worlds of fiction, when we cross the invisible boundaries of a game’s *magic circle* we enter a *playworld*—a “cosmos of its own”—in which our agential behavior is willingly shaped by the internal constraints provided by the rules (Riezler 1941, 505; Stenros 2014, 156).

The political and epistemological value of fiction—in the form of parafiction (Lambert-Beatty 2009), truthiness (War-

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6. The term *sub-creation* has been introduced by J.R.R. Tolkien to describe the human act of creating secondary imaginary worlds. For more information, see (Wolf 2014).

ren 2016), speculative fabulation and worlding (Haraway 2016), situated knowledge (Haraway 1988)—has been already established in the academic discourse of artistic research, while the potential of games—with their inherent distributed agency—deserves further investigation.

Ludic musicking aims to provide a methodological framework in which performers, composers and audience can inhabit a shared imaginary world of sounds that are both real and fictional. For example, corpus-based musical games allow their participants to explore and recombine a playing space of sounds constraint by a set of recognizable musical entities (Ghisi 2017). Furthermore, these systems have the potential to advocate alternative realities—ones in which inequalities and power relations of our culture could be overridden.

## 2 A Time Apart, A Place Apart

We are living in a fantasy world  
/ Together in a make-believe campaign /  
With mystic wizards, desperate heroes,  
mighty warriors  
A time apart, a place apart /  
In future and in past [...] In search  
of gold in empires lost /  
The universe is ours [...] Beyond this  
shadow world / Lies peace, and  
glory, and life<sup>7</sup>.

In reflecting about games and playful thinking, and their potential to shape our current ideas of art and aesthetic experiences, it would have been a missed opportunity not to present it in the form of

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7. This citation is an excerpt from a poem by Deron and Eric Johnson appearing as opening for (Fine [1983] 2002).

an actual game. Instead of classical academic reading—too often focusing on diagonal information retrieval and canonical referencing—the player/reader will take the role of a peculiar party of adventures seeking to retrieve the fragments of an ancient artefact belonging to a long forgotten civilization.

The reason behind this decision is not purely aesthetic, but motivated by the idea that knowledge can be acquired by interacting with a system, in this case a game—rather than a static written work—inviting both performer and audience, author and reader, towards *systems literacy*: an emerging form of knowledge and learning in order to understand the interwoven relations of our world <sup>8</sup>.

Struggle against unnecessary obstacles in order to pursue disposable ends is what makes the gaming experience so compelling (Costikyan 2005; Nguyen 2020). By adopting a *lusory attitude* we depart from our conventions, habits and biases and embrace the unexpected with the help of randomizers, regardless of whether they are cards, dice or other players' actions<sup>9</sup>. Once the player has stepped outside the *magic circle* of the game-world, their artificial experience has the power to change their view and attitude towards the actual world (Nguyen 2020). In ludic musicking performers

and audience alike take risks, embracing failure and experimental mindset in order to let—an otherwise impossible—aesthetic experience arise.

Every game-mechanic described in the [Appendix](#) functions as an emblem, a door opening an inner world beyond its in-game effect. By engaging with the game, the aim of this essay is to convey the idea of ludic musicking to the reader by actively experiencing it first hand—for as much the conventions of academic writing allow. Game-mechanics such as *The Wheel*, or the choice between the *Advance* or *Scout* actions, exemplifies concepts of player's agency by experiencing them through the interaction with the game-space. At every step of the dungeon exploration, the player(s) will be confronted with crucial decisions leading to meaningful actions. The abstract grid representing the dungeon becomes a tactile representation of the unfolding of the playing space into horizons of intent and action (Upton 2015).

## 2.1 The Statue is Superior to the Thing Itself

I would argue that the Statue is superior to the thing itself, the Statue being perfect, eternal and not subject to decay. (Clarke [2020] 2021, 222)

In Susanna Clarke's novel *Piranesi* (2020), the main character inhabits the rooms of a peculiar space: a seemingly infinite series of halls populated by ageless statues, depicting the entire gamut of human culture and nature. This parallel world is a silent custodian of mankind's history and ideas. Despite the statues' immovability, these universal archetypal figures defy unambiguous explanation: like games, their inherent ambiguity invites each one interacting with them to construct a coherent

8. According to Frank Lantz, systems literacy aims to understand complex entities, involving loops and emergence of behaviors that could not be understood from their constituent parts. "This new way of interacting with and understanding the world could be an essential factor in humanity's ability to evolve and flourish and perhaps even our ability to survive at all" (Lantz 2023).

9. Interesting examples of games that uses fellow players as randomizers in order to generate unexpected horizons are the worldbuilding games of Ben Robbins, such as *Microscope* (Robbins 2011), *Kingdom* (Robbins 2013) and *In This World* (Robbins 2023).



interpretation based on their motivations and perspective. Games—as well as *imagines agentes*—are structures of desire<sup>10</sup>.

The thirty-six rooms of our menacing dungeon—represented by cells on a 6 x 6 grid—are associated with the statue of a *decan*: an astrological entity widely used in art of memory treatises of the sixteenth century, such as Cornelius Agrippa’s *Occulta Philosophia* (1551) and Giordano Bruno’s *De umbris idearum* (1582). These bygone and emblematic images, originally deployed for divination and horoscopes, have become creative agents within the *ars combinatoria* techniques of Bruno and his contemporaries<sup>11</sup>.

Furthermore, each decan is associated with a citation and a dialectic analysis of the former, made possible by a playthrough recorded by the author and his colleagues at Orpheus Instituut in May 2026<sup>12</sup>.

Our playthrough takes its inspiration from a plethora of literary source. The convivial sphere at the table is inspired by the *Knights of the Dinner Table* comic book series (Jolly Blackburn 1990). Like many generations of tabletop role-playing games before us, we unleash—by playing to find out—the metaphorical and physical space of the megadungeon with a sincere, but not serious attitude. The use of a dialogue as expositional form echoes the multitude of early modern treatises of

philosophy, art and (pseudo) science, such as the astronomical and metaphysical treatise *De l’infinito universo e mondi* (Bruno [1584] 2013). Moreover, our choice for dialogue form is an ode to *The Grasshopper* by game studies pioneer Bernard Suits (Suits [1978] 1990). Finally, the dungeon delving format is inspired by gamebooks like the *Choose your Own Adventure* series (Montgomery and Packard 1979), and the storytelling and tile-based board games<sup>13</sup> *Forbidden Desert* (Leacock 2013), *Cartaventura: Lhasa* (Dupont and Ladagnous 2021), *Quoridor* (Marchiesi 1997) and the iconic *Labyrinth* (Kobbert 1986).

### 3 Closing Time<sup>14</sup>

In keeping with Giambattista Marino’s concept of wonder as the ultimate goal of poetry, this essay aims to ingest new wonder in musicking by encouraging a *lusory attitude* (Suits [1978] 1990, Ch. 3) towards repertoire and power relations—between composers, performers and audience—by continuous negotiation between the complex network of agents that constitute the wondrous process of music-making. The inherent openness of games is a fruitful laboratory for experiencing alternative realities and foreign modes of agency.

The depths of this imaginary dungeon invite us to reconsider our habits and biases by engaging with sound in a non-linear way, without the support of any convoluted, overly complicated, black-box architecture. Echoing game designer Joris Dormans, increasing complexity is not the key to achieve more interesting outcomes. It is through a simple set of rules and procedures that meaningful and rich game-play

10. I am paraphrasing here a citation attributed to game scholar Eric Zimmerman “Games are structures of desire”, reinterpreting the quote within my current exposition. I am associating the player’s *desire* with their interpretation and taste.

11. For a detailed discussion on the use of decans in Hermeticism and *ars combinatoria*, see (Yates [1964] 2022). For their historical evolution and application to astrology (Austin Coppock 2014).

12. The video recording is available in the Research Catalogue exposition [ludic\\_musicking\\_recording](#) and on YouTube.

13. For a comprehensive overview of twenty-first-century board game design, see (Arnaudo 2024).

14. My conclusion’s section title is inspired by the homonymous 1973 album by Tom Waits.

emerges (Dormans 2012, 37). Let's delve into the dungeon, shall we?

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